

Earthworm

Earthworms spend almost all of their lives underground, which means that it's sometimes easy to forget about them. However, their life cycle is highly memorable. Unlike most other animals, earthworms are hermaphrodites. This means that each individual worm has both male and female sex organs for producing a baby.

Clinging together

Each earthworm has a thick ring around it called a clitellum. This produces sticky mucus that helps a pair of worms cling together when they are mating. They exchange sperm, which end up fertilizing each other's eggs.

Earthworms usually mate on the surface of the ground.

Clitellum

Sperm and eggs are produced in organs at the front of the earthworm, between the clitellum and the head.

As the cocoon scoops them up, sperm and eggs mix together so that fertilization can happen.

Sperm received during mating is stored in tiny sacs inside the body.

Laying cocoons

After mating, each earthworm uses its clitellum to form a cocoon. This slides forward, picking up the sperm and eggs along the way, then slips off the front end of the worm.

The cocoon's hardened casing protects baby earthworms from predators and parasites.

See also

Find out about sequoia trees (54–55), dandelions (60–61), and oak trees (62–63), which, like most plants, carry both male and female sex organs.